would publish his translation in 'fascicules'—60-70-page documents usually published once a month. Eventually, he ended up publishing over 300 fascicules down the years." However, these prose translations are paraphrases; the Writers Workshop 18-Parva set is much longer.

"Before my father's passing, there were one and a half Parvas remaining," says Ananda. "I decided this work must be carried out by Pradip Bhattacharya, my father's closest disciple on the Sanskrit front."

For Pradip Bhattacharya, taking on this project was a way of giving back to his teacher. Back in 1968, Prof. Lal had given Bhattacharya the first batch of five fascicules to read. Upon noticing some errors, the student wrote back to the teacher, pointing them out. "He sent me back my letter with a note that said, 'I'm wrong and you're right'," Bhattacharya recalls. "Prof. Lal encouraged me to write a review of his translations. Sometime later, I found that Sahitya Akademi's journal, *Indian Literature*, had published my review across two consecutive issues. It was his way of encouraging me and my readings."

Bhattacharya's translations of the *Mokshadharma Parva* and the *Anusasana Parva* run into 1,000 and 1,200 pages, respectively. According to the translator, it's the "high seriousness" of Vyasa that sets the Mahabharata apart not just from other Indian epics, but also from classical texts around the world.

The last volume, *Anusasana Parva*, embodies this same "high seriousness" better than any of the other Parvas, according to Bhattacharya. It includes, most famously, Bhishma's dharma sequence, wherein the veteran warrior is awaiting death on a bed of arrows but uses his time to explain the true meaning of dharma to Yudhishthira. Hopefully, this new verse translation will bring out the finer points of the epic for an entirely new generation of readers. ■

Aditya Mani Jha



and white cow, is both sweetly docile with Vasishtha and energetically aggressive with Vishwamitra's soldiers.

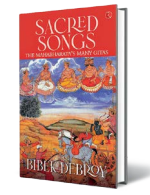
What I find interesting in this perspective is that Draupadi's humiliation after the gambling game is underplayed to the point of being absent in the pictures. The text clearly says that she was menstruating, that she wore but a single piece of cloth, that she was disrobed, and that Krishna protected her modesty. What we see in the single frame of a short series that depicts the episode is Draupadi covered from head to foot, Dushasana holding her hair, Draupadi addressing the elders and, possibly Vikarna, explaining that Yudhishthira had no right to stake her. The horrifying moment, so central to the development of the main story, is sublimated in the painting, protecting Draupadi's honour perhaps even more than Krishna could. If only we could know more about the social mores of the time that suggested, or perhaps demanded, this discretion and courtesy.

The editors of the book say this is a chance to enjoy "...the exciting dialogue between the verbal and visual imaginations of the poet and the painter". It's more than that: it's an entirely new way to experience the great daisy-chain of the Mahabharata's narrative. I'm so glad to have these books. ■

Arshia Sattar

Lessons from the Past

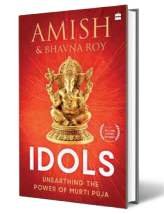
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by Amit Dixit